



Charter Schools: Impact on Houston

**Houston ISD lost an estimated
\$470,317,724 to charter schools just in 2024-25.**

A public school district can't simply cut costs dollar-for-dollar to the loss in revenue when a student transfers to a charter school because of fixed costs such as insurance, maintenance, and transportation. Instead, public school districts must cut expenses – often non-mandated programs and services. As a result, unlimited charter school expansion results in lost opportunities for students who choose to attend their public school district.

Estimated Revenue Loss to Charter Transfers (School Year 2024-2025) Select Greater Houston Public School Districts

District Name	District Enrollment	Charter Transfers	Charter Transfers as % of District Enrollment	Est. Revenue Loss to Charter Transfers
Houston ISD	176,727	53,954	30.5%	\$470,317,724
Alief ISD	38,610	9,825	25.4%	\$105,943,238
Fort Bend ISD	79,663	6,760	8.5%	\$62,827,704
Aldine ISD	56,419	6,105	10.8%	\$60,374,949
Cypress-Fairbanks ISD	117,927	5,392	4.6%	\$47,466,657
Pasadena ISD	46,491	4,409	9.5%	\$43,915,510
Spring ISD	33,590	4,319	12.9%	\$38,684,966
Katy ISD	96,111	3,834	4.0%	\$38,103,328
Klein ISD	52,437	1,838	3.5%	\$16,213,040
Spring Branch ISD	32,668	811	2.5%	\$7,412,249
Humble ISD	48,502	652	1.3%	\$6,233,360

Estimated revenue loss to charter transfers for all Texas public school districts is available.
Contact info@osod.org for more information.

Note: Student transfer counts are masked to comply with the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA). Masked numbers are typically small (<10 students) although larger numbers may be masked to prevent imputation of student personally identifiable information. The charter transfers count above is inherently conservative as it only includes student transfers from the district to charters where the count is unmasked.

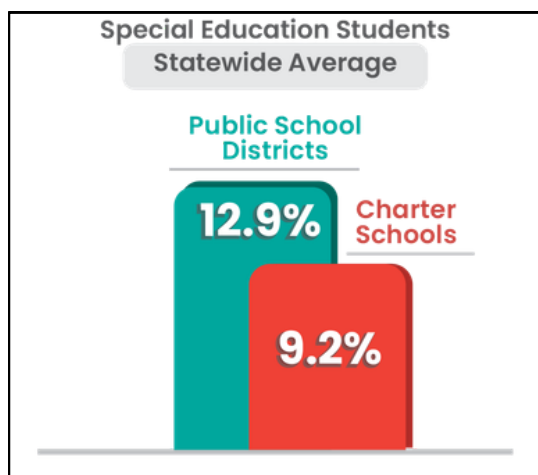
Analysis by Data for Public Education. Sources: Texas Education Agency – 2024-25 PEIMS District Transfer Reports, Student Enrollment Reports, and Summary of Finances.



Charter Schools: Impact on Houston

Charter schools across Houston routinely serve a lower percentage of special education students than the nearest district campuses

Unlike public school districts that are required to accept and enroll all students, charter schools can exclude certain students and underserve others. It's important to consider student demographics because **student demographics can have implications on student performance, school ratings, and finance.**



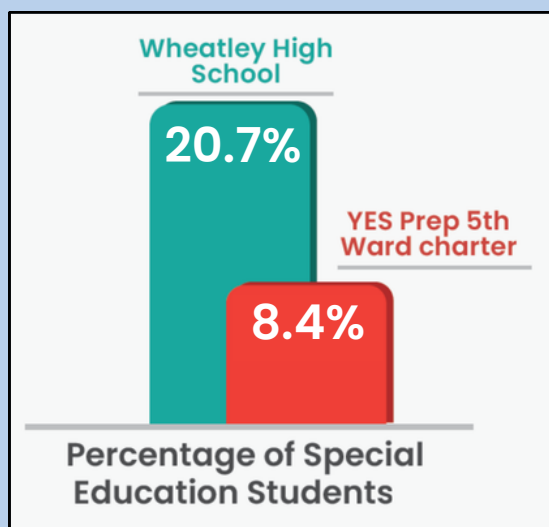
Graphic and data sources available in Facing Facts: Charter Schools in Texas (released by OSOD in 2025)

For example, charter schools have historically underserved special education students statewide compared to public school districts.

Disparities in student demographics are often much greater between charter school campuses and nearby public school district campuses. **Many district campuses serve several times the rate of special education students as charter school campuses of similar grade level just a few miles away.**

HISD Case Study: Wheatley High School

Wheatley High School's failure to receive a passing score on the state assessment for five years running was a primary reason for the state takeover of the entire Houston Independent School District in 2023. Yet, Wheatley has historically served a much higher percentage of special education students compared to the YES Prep 5th Ward charter school that is located only 1.2 miles from Wheatley.



Data sources available in Facing Facts: Charter Schools in Texas (released by OSOD in 2025)



Charter Campus	Students in Special Education %	District Campus (ISD)	Students in Special Education %	Distance
Bloom Academy Charter School	14.60%	Law Elementary (Houston ISD)	13.30%	1.2 mi
Etoile Academy Charter School	6.40%	Sutton Elementary (Houston ISD)	10.80%	1.1 mi
		Fondren Middle (Houston ISD)	7.30%	3.6 mi
Harmony School of Excellence - Houston	8.40%	Reed Elementary (Cypress-Fairbanks ISD)	22.20%	2.4 mi
		Dean Middle (Cypress-Fairbanks ISD)	16.30%	2.3 mi
Houston Gateway Academy Inc Elite College Prep	10.10%	Davila Elementary (Houston ISD)	18.90%	0.3 mi
		Deady Middle (Houston ISD)	21.10%	1.3 mi
IDEA Hardy Academy	8.90%	Scarborough Elementary (Houston ISD)	8.20%	1.2 mi
IDEA Hardy College Preparatory	12.00%	Patrick Henry Middle (Houston ISD)	17.40%	1.4 mi
		Houston Math, Science, and Technology Center High (Houston ISD)	12.30%	2.2 mi
ILTexas Houston Orem Middle	12.90%	Thomas Middle (Houston ISD)	23.00%	1.0 mi
KIPP Northeast College Preparatory	6.80%	North Forest High (Houston ISD)	13.10%	1.3 mi
The Lawson Academy	6.40%	Lockhart Elementary (Houston ISD)	11.50%	1.5 mi
		Cullen Middle (Houston ISD)	23.50%	1.9 mi



Charter Campus	Students in Special Education %	District Campus (ISD)	Students in Special Education %	Distance
Ser Ninos Charter Elementary	3.10%	Rodriguez Elementary (Houston ISD)	13.30%	0.5 mi
Southwest Public Schools Int'l Leadership Academy	8.20%	Bonham Elementary (Houston ISD)	7.60%	1.6 mi
The Varnett School Northeast	8.50%	Hilliard Elementary (Houston ISD)	12.70%	0.4 mi
		Forest Brook Middle (Houston ISD)	15.90%	3.0 mi
YES Prep Fifth Ward	8.40%	McReynolds Middle (Houston ISD)	22.90%	1.4 mi
		Wheatley High (Houston ISD)	20.70%	1.2 mi